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Examining space, silence, and agency in language socialization of an international student in the EAP and mainstream courses

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Abstract

This article draws on the concept of the Production of Space (Lefebvre, 1991) to interpret the silence of one female international student from Japan in two semesters of study in a New Zealand Tertiary institution. Data from an English for Academic Purposes course and mainstream courses, and from various sources including video/audio recordings of classroom interactions, interviews, diaries, field notes, institutional documents are presented. The findings show that silence is produced by the academic social space in three aspects of perceived, conceived, and lived. The new perceived space of learning positioned the focal student as unfamiliar in her new habitat. The conceived space also silenced the focal student because the conceived space exerted socio-academic norms in which the individual was not invested. Finally, the lived space produced a silent individual in the sense that she appeared as less powerful in her interactions with other peers because her sociocultural and linguistic capabilities were not on a par with those of other peers. The study concludes that space is an active, dynamic, and social being that regulates the individual's interactions and that silence should be understood in relation to one's positioning by the social space, and the appropriation of space by the individual in social space. Notably, despite being positioned as a silent individual by the academic social space, the international student exercised agency both

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to respond to her specific temporal needs in the host learning context and to realize her future aspirations.
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INTRODUCTION

Asian international students' silence in English language courses has been a critical issue (Nakane, 2007; Yashima, Ikeda, & Nakahira, 2016). Japanese students' silence, in particular, has been the subject of investigation (Anderson, 1993; Littlewood, 2000). The silence of Japanese students is often seen as a deficiency and a cultural characteristic (Flowerdew & Miller, 1995). However, these essentialized generalizations have been criticized as 'taken-for-granted cultural labels' and are, therefore, problematic (Kubota, 1999). Research evidence suggests that the use of silence by (Japanese) international students varies individually and could be viewed as "active participation" (Kim, Ates, Grigsby, Kraker, & Micek, 2016, p. 431), and "a form of engagement" (Bao, 2020, p. 31). Silence in interaction is both an inhibitive and facilitative element (Harumi & King, 2020), which should be contextually understood (Yoneyama, 2012). Existing literature also suggests that silence should be conceptualized as the space and venue for the potential formation or enactment of international students' identities and agency (Wu, 2019, p. 8). International students could therefore draw on silence as a strategy to mediate their social and academic identities.

Despite the recent developments in research on silence (King, 2013, 2016) and the importance of space in shaping and re-shaping international students' social and academic engagement in transnational mobility, the role of space in understanding their silence and agency in tertiary contexts has been under researched. Although silence and agency are central to international students' participation in the host environment, these notions in the context of international education are not often explicitly explained or adequately theorized. To that end, silence is reconsidered as the time other participants in social space engage in talk while some choose not to contribute verbally for a specified period of time. This article draws on the production of space (Lefebvre, 1991) to respond to this critical gap in the literature by reporting on an in-depth analysis of one international student's class participation, using a qualitative case study methodology, in a New Zealand tertiary institution. The rich data were collected from multiple sources including weekly video/audio recordings of classroom

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interactions, weekly interviews with the focal student and interviews with her tutors, weekly diaries by the focal student, researcher's weekly classroom observations and field notes, institutional documents, and class materials. The findings about the focal student's language socialization suggest that silence should be understood in connection to the perceived, conceived, and lived aspects of space. An in-depth analysis of this student's experience shows that in understanding silence, it is important that we consider how the individual is positioned in and by his/her physical space, how he/she is socialized into the norms, and how he/she interacts with others and understands his/her relationship with others in the lived space. Importantly, the findings of the study show that despite being silent because of the ecological conditions in which the student is situated, she exercised different forms of agency to gain access to her learning community and make the best of her academic and social situation.

Theoretical Framework

Academic social space. To understand the focal student's experience and silence, the theoretical framework of academic social space (Soltani, 2015, 2018) was used. This framework drew on language socialization (Ochs & Schieffelin, 2008), agency, and production of space (Lefebvre, 1991) to situate the students' experiences in an ecological perspective (Steffensen & Kramsch, 2017; Van Lier, 2006). This perspective encourages us to consider the interplay between the dynamics of various forces in the social space in understanding the focal student's participation in her new academic social space.

Language socialization. Language socialization theory examines how people become more effective members of their community of practice (CofP henceforward) and the role language plays in this process (Schieffelin & Ochs, 1986, p. 167). Socialization is of two types: people are socialized either through language or to use language so that they become experienced members of their relevant communities and social groups (Kulick & Schieffelin, 2004, p. 350). Second language (L2) researchers have used this theory to examine the L2 and social development of learners within the context of L2 culture (Duff & Doherty, 2019; Kobayashi, Zappa-Hollman, & Duff, 2017; Soltani, 2015, 2021a, 2021b; Soltani & Tran, 2021; Soltani & Zhang, 2021). The cultural, social, and political context where people learn a language determines not only what linguistic forms they hear and use but also how socially significant are the linguistic and cultural forms they are exposed to and use (Watson-Gegeo, 2004, p. 334). Second language socialization research has investigated the complex nature of international students' participation in their discourse communities (Kinginger, 2017; Soltani, 2018). Using language

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socialization and a CofP perspective, Morita (2004) illustrated meanings behind the silence of six Japanese female participants in a Canadian university. She showed how her participants employed their agency to negotiate their second language learning and participation in their new second language contexts. The current study used an academic social space perspective (Soltani, 2015, 2018) to interpret the verbal non-participation of a Japanese student in a second language space.

Agency. Agency is the sociocultural capacity of a person to act (Ahearn, 2001). Drawing on a developmental subject-oriented lens to agency, Billett (2006) argues that there is a relational interdependence between the individual and the social structure when considering the development of an individual across their life, and the connection between the individual and the social context. Agency functions within and through social structures relationally and is linked to their immediate social context (Billett, 2006). Hence, actions that are performed by the individuals always have a social basis. Within a developmental subject oriented stance, participation in social space is linked to identities and subjectivities and the role of individual as an active agent and actor in this process. Actions not only have a social genesis, but could also initiate from the experience and personal histories of the individual which could enact individuals' intentionality and subjectivity (Eteläpelto, Vähäsantanen, Hökkä, & Paloniemi, 2013, p. 56).

Production of space. To interpret the language socialization and silence of the focal student in this study, we use the notion of production of space from Henri Lefebvre, 1991, a French philosopher and sociologist. Lefebvre (1991) was concerned about human condition. He stressed the need to conflate the different strands of thought so we could more fully appreciate how individuals think, behave, and act (Lefebvre, 1991). Social scientists, sociologists, and mathematicians have previously separated different aspects of space (Merrifield, 2006). To reconnect the various aspects of space, Lefebvre (1991, p. 33) argues that space is all about social space which consists of three aspects: spatial practice (also called physical space or perceived space), representations of space (also called conceived/mental/imagined space), and spaces of representations (also called lived space) which are explained below.

1. Spatial practice refers to the material space around us, the space that is tangible and is understood by all the people around us. This aspect of social space creates an opportunity for navigation.

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2. Representations of space are the space of designers, policy makers, artists, politicians, urbanists, and technocrats. It is in this aspect of space where knowledge and power are articulated. It is the space of those with power. Thus, in this aspect of space the interests and desires of people with power are reflected.
3. Spaces of representation are lived spaces. This aspect of space is where individuals meet others in social space. This aspect of social space is where those who are not endowed with power resist what is not favorable to them. The three aspects of social space are dialogically intertwined and work together as a whole.

In this study, perceived space, conceived space, and lived space are used to refer to spatial practice, representations of space, and spaces of representation respectively. Lefebvre claims that previous theories about space fetishized space because the epistemological ground of those theories considered space as an object (Burgel, Burgel, & Dezes, 1987). Lefebvre means that there is a fetishizing of space because people regard it as an object and forget that it is the result of social relationships and social relation of production. Therefore, our everyday life as we experience it – our social space – remains under-studied.

Drawing on the above theories, language socialization is reconceptualized taking a spatial perspective. Language socialization, then, is a complex process, which is itself a social product comprising of perceived, conceived, and lived aspects of space, through which the newcomers to a social space learn the norms of the conceived space from the more experienced social agents by strategically negotiating their social space and endeavor to be more effective members of their social space. This process is not linear (Ross, 1988) as it involves both acceptance and denial of individuals in the social space and comprises their investments, positionings, and negotiations all occurring in social space. Language socialization is then dialogical as the aspects of space are not separate from one another and consists of both unifying and segregating forces (Stanek, 2011) in social space. Therefore, anytime we talk about language socialization we need to ask ourselves where the social space is, what the rules, norms, and expectations the designers of that social space have set up, and how individuals experience that social space as they come across other social agents with various power relations, investments, hopes, intentions, and desires for future. The inclusion of the three aspects of space, particularly the perceived space which was largely ignored in language socialization theory injects dynamicity and dialogicality to the theory of language socialization. This enriches our understanding of individuals' experiences in their social spaces.

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In understanding the focal student's language socialization and silence, we did not consider any fixed, ethnic, cultural, or linguistic traits for her to avoid overgeneralization. Instead, we demonstrated the role of space in her socialization as an active being which shaped her experience of socialization in the academic social space of her New Zealand university.

Research Questions and Methods

This study was part of a larger study that investigated the second language socialization of six international students in a New Zealand university (NZU hereafter). The study specifically investigated how the students socialized themselves and were socialized by others and the role of social space in this process. The students' interactions particularly in the oral activities were explored because it is yet a relatively under-studied domain.

In the present study, one focal student's experience is presented because in so doing we will be able to better capture the experience of this student in her academic social space with more breadth and depth. The central questions of this study were as follows:

1. How did the focal student participate in her classroom oral activities?
2. How did the focal student socialize herself and was socialized by others in her classroom's communities of practice?
3. How did space as a social being participate in the focal student's socialization?

The focal student took an EAP course in the first semester followed by three courses in the mainstream program: European Studies, Spanish, and Academic Writing. The researcher collected data about the focal student for two semesters of study (2011–2012) in two phases. The first phase was in an EAP course and the second course in a mainstream Writing course. The researcher video/audio recorded the focal student's interactions in her classes on a weekly basis during which the researcher took field notes of his observations. The researcher conducted fortnightly and then weekly interviews with the focal student, which lasted between 15 and 60 minutes. In total, the researcher video/audio recorded 14.5 hours of EAP classes and 32.5 hours in the mainstream program. The first interview followed a semi-structured format where the researcher asked about the focal student's language proficiency, academic background, and why she chose to come to New Zealand. The next interviews followed an open-ended format which addressed the focal student's participation in her courses.

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The focal student also chose to write weekly diaries about her participation in her classes. Apart from the interviews with the focal student, the researcher interviewed her EAP teacher and mainstream tutor at the end of the courses so that the researcher could ask about their thoughts with regards to the focal student participation, interactions, and performance during the course and if they observed any changes. The researcher also used the class materials in EAP course and mainstream writing course and online institutional documents relevant to courses in which the focal student was enrolled. In the interviews, the focal student talked about her participation in her class on that day and then during the week. She then reflected on any possible changes in her participation and other students' participation in class. She also talked about her challenges in the courses and the possible reasons behind her silence, and strategies she would use to overcome some of those challenges. The interviews provided an opportunity for the focal student and the researcher to dig deeper into what the researcher observed in the classroom and recorded in the videos. The interviews were conducted in English.

To understand the complexities of the focal student's language socialization in her L2 academic social space, this study adopted a longitudinal case study research design (Yin, 2014). This enabled the researcher to produce a longitudinal account of the participant's everyday life experiences for two semesters of study from her perspective (Denzin & Lincoln, 2011).

The study employed various sources of data and the researcher made use of the relevant analytical approaches which served to answer the research questions best. Discourse analysis (Jones, 2012) with a particular focus on the content and themes is employed to analyze the naturalistic data from the focal student. The method which could capture the experiences of focal student in her material, conceived, and lived spaces was not a set of scientifically measurable variables because they are not likely to produce rich descriptions about the nature of such experiences on a day-to-day basis (Norton, 2013). This approach allowed for a naturalistic analysis, which is a process where the researcher examines "the social acts which are forged into joint actions the [researcher] records, interactive conduct that is linguistically produced, spatially situated, and temporally organized" (Denzin, 1971, p. 171). Using this analysis, the interviews, observations, diaries, field notes and the participants' interactions were coded in NVivo. The study adopted InVivo coding, through which all the expressions and phrases used by the focal student ("...didn't speak in class"), were coded. All coding about students' engagement in class activities in each phase, for example, formed a theme. Examples of themes emerging from the analysis of the data

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were: Feedback, debate, critical thinking, oral presentations and the negotiations she made about each theme in her new and prior social spaces. The themes were then considered in terms of the three aspects of space i.e., perceived, conceived, and lived spaces which constituted her experience in the academic social space. At the same time, data were presented chronologically to trace the socialization of the focal student at the beginning, in the middle of, and toward the end of her study in the New Zealand university.

The study triangulated various data collection methods and sources and included multiple perspectives which enabled the researcher to come up with a rich description of the focal student. Pseudonyms have been used in this study to protect the identity of the participants. The next section introduces the focal student and the researcher followed by an analysis of the focal student's language socialization in her second language academic social space.

The focal student and the researcher. Shelly was born in Osaka, which is one of the most metropolitan areas in Japan. At the time of the data collection, she was 19 years old and a sojourner at NZU, which was located in one of New Zealand's most urban and diverse cities. She had already studied International Studies for one and a half years in a Japanese university. Because her Japanese university and NZU had an exchange program, she had chosen to study at NZU. Shelly came to New Zealand for 1 year to study English and a few undergraduate courses toward a degree in International Studies from her university in Japan. In the interview, Shelly described herself as belonging to a middle-class family in Japan (Interview data, 29.11.2011). Shelly had Intermediate proficiency at the time of the study and was able to produce simple speech fluently. The course she took part in was an English for Academic Purposes course designed to prepare those for whom English was an additional language for university study.

Shelly often traveled to other places because her dad could speak English. On her trip to Guam Island she met a beautiful flight attendant who became Shelly's motivation to pursue a degree in International Studies and English at the university so that she could fulfill her dream of becoming a flight attendant (Interview data, 29.05.2012).

The researcher had 14 years of experience in teaching English as an additional language at the time of data collection in Iran and in New Zealand and was doing his PhD at a New Zealand research intensive university. The researcher taught in the same EAP program and Shelly already knew him. The researcher had already established a good relationship with the EAP teachers, which facilitated his entry to

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the EAP classrooms. At the start of the data collection, the researcher had a meeting with the focal student and asked her what she wanted to get out of the project. She asked the researcher to have speaking practice with her, correct her grammatical mistakes, amend her pronunciation, explain to her the essay structure, and if she could practice her oral presentation with the researcher and receive feedback. Given that the researcher had already taught in the program and was well familiar with the expectations of that program, following De Costa (2015), he acted as a "researcher as resource" (Candlin & Sarangi, 2003, p. 279). During the data collection, he attended the focal student's classes, interviewed her, first fortnightly then weekly, took fieldnotes, and interviewed her tutor and teachers for two semesters of study. Furthermore, to appreciate the teachers, he acted in an appropriate professional manner so that his presence would not add up pressure to their already stretched schedules. He also asked the focal student to determine when and where she wanted to have the interviews. During the course of the interview, the researcher used a kind of language which was comprehensible to the focal student so that he mitigated power relations between her and himself (Talmy, 2010). As for the reporting process, the researcher was careful how to represent his data so that he could protect his participants and did not represent himself as "researcher as expert" (Candlin & Sarangi, 2003, p. 280).

The perceived aspect of space and the positioning of Shelly as a silent individual. In what follows, data are presented from the 5th week of her EAP course about how she viewed her prior and new perceived spaces in terms of the landscapes, scenery, population, amenities, transportation, and climate both in New Zealand and in Japan. Shelly found two contrasting perceived spaces:

> New Zealand is countryside and there is a lot of green and lots of sheep, and less people. The Japan is urban. Lots of building, lots of company, and lots of people. No convenience store like Japan. And there are not big shopping centers and less transportation compared to Japan. [Name of New Zealand city] changeable weather like today. It was raining today and now it is sunny. Very strange (Interview data, 29.11.2011).

Her description above indicates that Shelly characterized her previous perceived space in Japan with all features of an urban society including huge landscapes, companies, many inhabitants, shopping malls, convenience stores, and a huge transportation system characteristic of a modern metropolis. Contrary to that, she found her new perceived space in New Zealand lacking city attractions and one where

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she could find herself in less populated green countryside full of cattle with unstable weather conditions. The unfamiliarity with the new perceived space made her feel unfamiliar in the new social space. It should though be mentioned that there are rural regions in Japan and urban regions in New Zealand. The unfamiliarity with the new perceived space made her feel unfamiliar in the new social space. Also, she said,

> When I have free time, there is nothing to do here. So I am always free after class (Interview data, 29.11.2011).

Unlike her previous perceived space where she was busy all the time with the attractions and the entertainment that her city offered, in her new perceived space because of the lack of all these amenities, she had "a lot of free time" and "could relax." The new perceived space made her have little to do that limited her interactions to just the school and the supermarket.

She also mentioned that the arrangements of the furniture in the classroom made her silent.

> In New Zealand, we should talk around the table. In Japan, [we] did not sit like this. At table we only have chance to talk to students, not teacher. Sometimes I don't know if answers is right. So, I don't talk. I want to check with teacher. It is sometimes hard. In Japan, we received feedback from teacher not students (Interview data, 10.05.2012).

Shelly's classrooms were "set up in groups or U-shaped desks and the learning objectives derive[d] the physical arrangement of the furniture and also where the students were standing or sitting" (Interview with EAP Director, 23.05.2013). If the learning objectives required the students to work in teams, they were usually grouped in three or four around a table where they could discuss the questions or issues as a group. If there were whole class discussions, the students usually had to share their thoughts with peer(s) next to them or to the whole class where they could also see other peers' reactions to their ideas. Shelly felt the seating arrangements in her new perceived space made her listen to classmates most of the time and did not give a chance to get feedback from the teacher, which was instrumental to her taking a silent position.

To appropriate her physical space, she thought of finding ways to make better use of her perceived space around her.

> [I] used the facilities at NZU, I changed my study place and I started to use library or computer room at NZU and I became to study easily and I could concentrate on my work (Interview data, 10.05.2012).

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As indicated above, facilities helped her shape her socialization. Shelly used the facilities in her new social space to promote her learning. The lack of amenities and city attractions in her new perceived space regulated her behavior (Lefebvre, 1991, p. 38), and positioned her as a silent individual in her new perceived space as she thought she had a lot of free time. Shelly was the sort of person who used the material space of her Japanese city to socialize and have fun with her friends. Lack of those amenities in her new social space prevented her from having the relevant social practices associated with that such as going out with friends to the shopping malls, and entertainment places (Interview data, 29.11.2011).

The conceived and lived aspects of space and the positioning of Shelly as a silent individual. This section shows how Shelly was positioned as silent in her conceived and lived aspects of space. In what follows, extracts from her participation in EAP and mainstream courses are given to show her positionings in her academic social space.

Shelly's participation in EAP course. Below, a sample from the EAP class of a small group interaction between Shelly and her peers in her 6th week of the course is given. Students in the group had listened to a few other students' oral presentations and were giving feedback on their work. The presenters moved from one table to another to listen to their classmates' feedback. Charles, a Chinese student, was now talking to students at Shelly's table (Field notes, 08.12.2011).

Extract 1.

1. Charles: Hello.
2. Shelly: Hi.
3. Jack: You well done. Good organization and,
4. Shelly: Yeah.
5. Jack: and one recommendation for you is you write too many words.
6. Charles: I recommend, I READ?! [Rising intonation]
7. Jack: You write.
8. Charles: But how do you think? I read my PPT notes.
9. Jack: You write too many words on your PPT.
10. Charles: But,
11. James: It's difficult to follow your PPT or your words.
12. Charles: Yeah.
13. Brian: And don't show hands they are in your pocket.

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14. Shelly: Yeah! [Smiles].
15. Charles: Because I don't know where hands should put in. When I give presentation
16. in China, I have microphone. So I take microphone and with the gestures. It is not
17. very good. Uh.
18. Jack: it's not good. Any others?
19. Brian: I thought your turn.
20. Jack: Why always me?
21. Shelly: [Laughs].
22. Brian: We know it's your turn now.
23. Shelly: Yes. I wish I were you.
24. Charles: You always envy us [speaking English]. Shelly, it's your turn now.
25. Shelly: I agree with you [Smiles].
26. Charles: You always agree with us.
27. Sarah: Do you have any suggestions [to Shelly]?
28. Shelly: I think that was very perfect (Classroom interaction data, 08.12.2011).

In this extract, students were supposed to provide Charles with comments about his presentation. Although other students gave him comments, Shelly did not mention any specific points and issues about his presentation. In line 4, she said "yeah" to confirm that she, too, had enjoyed Charles' PPT slides. This was followed by a nodding of the head, "yeah," and "smile" in lines 14, 21, and 23. In line 24, when the speaker expected students' feedback on the different aspects of his lecture like pronunciation, fluency, and body language, Shelly just mentioned that she envied her friends' speaking ability. She gave no criticism to her friend and just told him that everything had been flawless (lines 25 and 28). In this instance, Shelly might rely on proactive silence as a way to cope with her insecurity because she felt her spoken English was not as good as her friends'.

In her 7th week of the EAP course, in an interview with Shelly, the researcher asked her why she did not contribute much to class discussions.

Researcher: Could you tell me why you choose not to speak?

Shelly: Because I afraid of mistaking.

Researcher: Why are you afraid of making mistakes?

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Shelly: Because I am ashamed to make mistake.

Researcher: Any other reasons?

Shelly: In my Japanese university, there are not enough chance to talk, speak in front of people. So, I am still ashamed to speak, maybe (Interview data, 14.12.2011).

One of Shelly's challenges was her unfamiliarity with classroom discourse at NZU followed by her fear of making mistakes. She frequently reported that she did not have "enough ideas" to share with her classmates. Again Shelly was proactively silent in the face of unfamiliarity and insecurity because the fact that students had to criticize and/or give feedback on their peers' work was something she was newly introduced to at NZU and was not yet confident about. Belcher (1995) maintains that it is not a realistic view to assume that students will eventually reach a level where they will be critical thinkers. Students require training so that they engage in the transformation of knowledge instead of simply regurgitating (Belcher & Braine, 1995; Leki & Carson, 1994). International students like Shelly may need more time to embark on their knowledge when they are writing. However, in speaking situations where they have to speak and critique their fellows spontaneously, they will have more problems. Shelly saw herself as not having the linguistic means and the proper academic tools to give feedback in her classes. Therefore, she thought if she spoke ungrammatical English, she would lose face (Choi, 2015) which would be humiliating for her.

However, she did participate non-verbally by using gestures e.g., nodding, smiling, and she agreed verbally by providing a "yes" token. When it was her turn to contribute, she did not make any efforts to move the conversation forward and add or challenge any ideas.

To probe further, the researcher referred to her participation in the endangered species task discussed in Extract1 above:

Researcher: The previous time I observed you, you read the article but did not engage in a conversation about it with your friends and just read the questions to them. Your group members contributed a lot when you read the questions. However, when it came their turn, and they were talking, you remained silent. Can you explain why you are so silent?

Shelly: I don't know. It's like characteristic.

Researcher: Would you choose not to talk if the conversation were in Japanese

Shelly: I just say something. Um.

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Researcher: So you try to say something even if the topic is new to you. But in English you choose to be silent.

Shelly: Yeah. I want speak but I cannot speak very well. So, I am silent.

Researcher: Tell me about how you feel at that time. For example, when Bardia and Tim were talking, you were not actually saying anything. But by saying yeah and/or smiling you showed you were following them.

Shelly: I feel that they are good at speaking English but I can't. But actually I won't say anything. I cannot express my idea very well in English…

Researcher: So?

Shelly: Because I am not used to speak English. But I want to speak in my mind. Iwant to speak English fluently in my mind. But I don't speak (Interview data,14.12.2011).

Shelly strategically drew on pro-active silence, which refers to the way she exercised agency through resorting to silence to create a safe space and a sense of security. She enumerated several reasons which were influential in her verbal non-participation in class interactions. She always constructed "others" as better language learners (Norton & Toohey, 2001), hence, singling out herself from the rest of her group members and giving herself a lower status compared with her fellow classmates. In addition, she pointed out that speaking in the classroom was just a new kind of genre for which she did not have enough experience in her previous academic social space in Japan. Thus, she needed to empower herself through pro-active silence initially and gradually socializing herself into the new academic expectations of interacting with other group members. In interaction 1, she mainly did it by observing what her other classmates whom she thought were better language learners were doing. In so doing, she learned the new norms of her conceived space but at the same time she stayed in the periphery of her classroom's CofP. Shelly's accounts above suggest that she did not want to be silent, and she was not passively silent. Instead, she indeed wanted to participate in activities. However, because of the conditions of her social space, she strategically used pro-active silence to gain a sense of security, and empower herself (Wu, 2019, p. 8), which speaks to the fact that silence was not an inherent trait for her.

Three days after the EAP course finished, the researcher interviewed Shelly's EAP teacher and asked her about Shelly's participation. She mentioned that Shelly did not enjoy the course contents which made her contribute less to the discussions which could well be another reason for her pro-active silence prohibiting Shelly from participating in class activities as illustrated below.

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> She was the least confident person in the class compared to all the others. I think because EAP course focuses on academic topics, there, maybe, uh she was talking about, they were not particularly of interest or relevance to her. Well, when we were doing the independent learning project she was, she chose to talk about tourism. And tourism, I think tourism is a likely option when she goes to a university course. And of all the activities we did that was probably where she spoke most confidently (Interview with teacher, 13.02.2012).

Shelly's EAP teacher thought as Shelly was not able to fully relate to the topics which were more academic, she contributed minimally to the discussions. She also implied that Shelly was not an academic type of person who would show an interest in academic topics (Potowski, 2007). In an interview with the researcher, Shelly mentioned that she wanted to "become a flight attendant and travel the world" (Interview data, 29.05.2012). Hence, she showed a lot of interest to the tourism theme in her EAP course.

Shelly's participation in mainstream program. In what follows Shelly's experience in the mainstream program is discussed, and her participation in European Studies, Spanish, and writing courses is showcased.

Shelly's participation in the European Studies course. Shelly withdrew from the European Studies course. In the 2nd week of her mainstream program and after her first session in the European Studies course she wrote the researcher the following:

> I took lecture of European studies today, but it was too difficult for me. I could not understand anything what teacher was talking. The lecture has lots of lots of academic wards [SIC] I don't know. Moreover, I did assignment yesterday, but there are so many new words in the reading materials, so I spent 6 hours on it. But I could not understand the reading, and i could not answer the questions of it because it was so difficult (Diary data, 12.03.2012).

> As evident above, soon after she took her first session of European Studies course, Shelly understood she could not participate in the course at all and was horrified at the amount of work required for that course. Therefore, right after her first lecture she emailed the researcher and asked for an appointment. She reported that there were many native speakers of English such as New Zealanders and Americans in her European Studies course. But there were very few students with English as an additional language in that class which made her feel really upset. The presence of many native speakers of English in the European Studies course resulted in her feeling completely powerless (Wu, 2019, p. 8).

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Shelly's participation in the Spanish course. Shelly reported that her participation in the Spanish course was minimal. In addition, her silence remained unchanged. Although Shelly was psychologically more comfortable with the status quo because English was not the medium of instruction, she faced another challenge. She struggled to communicate with her peers, who were L1 speakers of English because they often used English as a mode of communication in a speed that exceeded Shelly's comprehension abilities. As a result, she was put in a silent position in her classroom social space when it came to interactions with native speakers of English. However, as Spanish was an additional language in New Zealand, she was not pressured in the classroom. Shelly and her female friend from the same university in Japan were placed among New Zealand and American students in the Spanish course. Although Shelly said she did not contribute much in her Spanish course, she felt she was safe because the medium of communication was no longer English:

Researcher: What do you like most about Spanish class?

Shelly: The people who are not who don't speak English as the first language, it is comfortable for me. In Spanish course, everyone except I and my friend is from New Zealand or USA so they have to learn about only Spanish but I have to learn English and Spanish. So it is hard for Japanese people.

Researcher: Um. Do you usually speak in your Spanish class

Shelly: Not so many. In tutorial class, we have discuss and have a chance to speak butin Spanish.

Researcher: Do the other students in your Spanish class contribute to the discussions?

Shelly: Uh, if they have a question they ask to the tutor but not so many. During the discussion time, we talk but the tutor talks the explanation of the exercise, we are quiet (Interview data, 27.04.2012).

Shelly experienced a different social space in her Spanish course. In Spanish class, she and her friend were the only non-English speaking students. Other students shared the same mother tongue, and they could communicate with each other quickly in English. Shelly reported that because of her English proficiency level, she could not get what they were saying in English (Interview data, 27.04.2012). Therefore, she could not maintain a conversation with other students in class. However, she felt relatively safe as she was aware that Spanish was also an additional language for the rest of the classmates. Therefore, she thought that she would be able to manage, and learn the new language in class by paying attention to what the teacher was saying and at the

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same time following the exercises in the textbook. Although Shelly was learning a new language (i.e., Spanish), and she was surrounded by native speakers of English, she did not see this as a problem mainly because all students were learning a new language where knowing English was not regarded as a main advantage in their classroom identity construction and hence was not considered as an element of power which would position Shelly as inferior (Eteläpelto et al., 2013).

Shelly's participation in the writing course. In Extract 2 below, Shelly's interaction in the 6th week of her writing course is provided and her identity construction and the changes she underwent in her socialization in her new socio-academic space are analyzed.

The teacher asked students to write what they knew about capital punishment before they read an article about capital punishment in New Zealand. Shelly and a Malaysian student were paired together to brainstorm and share their ideas about capital punishment laws in their own countries (Field notes, 24.04.2012).

Extract 2.

1. Malay female: In my country I think people are being hanged for extreme cases like
2. murder. How about in your country?
3. Shelly: Yeah. In Japan we have capital punishment. But, uh, I don't know so much
4. [Laughter].
5. Malay female: Yeah. We hear it from TV.
6. Shelly: Yeah, yeah.
7. Malay student: Which one do you think is the most cruel way, hanging or the
8. electric chair?
9. Shelly: In Japan, the electric chair is common, maybe.
10. Malay female: I think the electric chair is the worst cruel way to kill people.
11. Shelly: Yeah.
12. Malay female: Before they die, yeah, they have to suffer long before they die.
13. Maybe the way of punishment is very compatible with what they did, their
14. wrongdoings.
15. Shelly: Um. Does your country have capital punishment?

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16. Malay female: In my country they cover the head with a black cloth and then they
17. pick up head [Hahaha] (Classroom interaction data, 24.04. 2012).

In this interaction, Shelly and a Malay student were discussing how their countries dealt with capital punishment. In line 1, Malay female initiated the talk. What is interesting is that Shelly gave a rather long answer compared with her previous class contributions. Then what was particularly significant in line 15 was that Shelly initiated a turn by asking a question which was the first time in the class data about Shelly where she asked something.

The change in Shelly's participation pattern was in line with the language socialization theory that newcomers to a new community first stay in the periphery and then by observing the more expert or more experienced members move toward the center of the activities. It further proves that Shelly's silence was not a deficiency but a purposeful strategy to allow her to better socialize herself to the social space of her classroom.

In the 11th week of her mainstream program, Shelly wrote about the role of class materials in her socialization in academic writing norms.

> From class materials I could learn a lot of skills such as how to write references in a essay. I learned it in EAP course, but I could know about it more detail in this course (Diary data, 28.05.2012).

As the diary data show, although Shelly had become familiar with academic writing in her EAP course, she thought that it was during her writing course that tasks strengthened her learning of the academic writing norms (see Appendix C for an example of classroom materials). She found that the tasks encouraged the learners to not only interact but also "critique" each other's work and seek peer feedback (online institutional documents).

Shelly's agency and social change. Despite all the challenges, Shelly exercised her agency to reposition herself. In what follows, data are presented from Shelly's 8th week in the mainstream program, where her different strategies to negotiate her new social space and the expectations it exerted upon her are shown. The interview data below introduce her accounts of her transformations in terms of feedback, communication with others, taking control of social media, and the benefits she gained from participating in this research.

Shelly: I learned to do peer feedback especially in the writing class. So if my friends advise about my essay I can rewrite and write better than before . . .

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Um: I think, [I learned to] communicate. Uh, before I have studied in my room, but I cannot concentrate on my work because I always check my Facebook or Twitter. I changed my study place and I started to use library or computer room at NZU and I became to study easily and I could concentrate on my work [Laughter].

Researcher: Do you think your participation in my research has helped you in any ways?

Shelly: I have learned because I can uh, I can talk every week so in English. It is very useful. I learned uh when I eh did presentation in EAP you helped me a lot so that was very useful and [I am] thanksful [for that]... Uh, eh, I don't think about me seriously. Myself seriously, but when you asked me about me I can think about me (Interview data, 10.05.2012).

Shelly as shown above transformed herself by improving her speaking because she was able to converse with the researcher once a week during two semesters. She also learned to deliver an oral presentation based on NZU norms. On top of that she paid more attention to herself because taking part in identity research helped her think about herself more seriously.

Apart from what she discussed above, the researcher's class observations and interviews with Shelly showed that she made various changes. To make up for her "lack of ideas," Shelly made an attempt to visit different educational websites mainly introduced by her English teacher and gather the relevant information she needed to survive in her discussions. She thought that this could give her enough confidence to think about the broader picture. Another strategy she developed was doing her best to develop good PowerPoint slides so that she could deliver a more interesting presentation. Furthermore, she made a conscious effort to listen to other people's feedback carefully and use the relevant information in her course. In the mainstream program, she learned to apply what she had learned in EAP to the Writing course. She started to ask the teacher questions at the end of the second semester. Moreover, she started to negotiate meaning with her Japanese friend both in the Spanish and the Writing classes so that she could find a way to do the assignments better. She also communicated more with her Chinese buddy to improve her English. Among other things, she joined a dance club to develop her network of friends beyond the classroom level. She managed to independently finish her assignments. And finally, she learned how to take control of the social networks such as Facebook and Twitter so that she would not spend a lot of time on them. Despite being positioned as silent in the academic social context, Shelly is not submissive and disengaged. In contrast, she is an "agentic being" with the capacity to draw on various

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strategies as discussed above to realize her specific academic and social needs. This expression of agency is termed as "needs-response agency" (Tran & Vu, 2018), arising from the conditions of relocating and adapting to an unfamiliar transnational mobility. Shelly's lived experiences shared through the interviews also demonstrate how she exercised "agency for becoming" which is related to self-transformation and engagement in "space of possibles" for themselves (Tran & Vu, 2018). Her self-transformation in terms of engaging in peer feedback, communication with others and taking control of social media has enabled her to become a more engaged learner and member of the host environment. Purposeful utilization of these strategies is an essential step toward a "transformative experience" in learning and socialization (Pugh, 2011, p.111).

DISCUSSION

King (2016, p. 146) argued that single cause-effect explanations for learners' silence do not do justice to understanding their silent behavior in the classroom. He referred to learner internal factors including L2 processing, identity construction, and affect besides a wide range of external environmental factors including elements and agents at classroom, institutional, and societal levels. Although he saw silence as a sum of variables and elements which are interconnected, he did not see it as the product of social space which is produced in the social space of the classroom and wider society. Drawing on Lefebvre (1991, p. 33) production of space framework and using data from the class interaction, field notes, interviews, diaries, class material, and institutional documents, we examined Shelly's interactions in her social space. Shelly's data showed that she negotiated all aspects of her social space including perceived, conceived, and lived. She negotiated the perceived space i.e., the tangible, concrete aspect of space, in this case the University buildings, facilities, classrooms, and other premises and wider New Zealand context. Shelly's data showed that the arrangement of the furniture (i.e., group and U-shaped format) required a certain way of interaction. Her unfamiliarity with this format positioned her as a silent individual in her classroom. She was also positioned by the wider perceived space as a silent individual because she felt her previous perceived space in Japan allowed more interactions with the members of the wider public, hence she felt she was unfamiliar in the new perceived space and not a creature of the new habitat. Therefore, she thought that impacted on how she used the social space and her interactions wherein.

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Shelly also negotiated the conceived spaces of New Zealand and Japan, i.e., the way University educationalists, policy makers, and designers think of space. The conceived space of the university promoted critical/creative thinking and peer feedback played a central role in the learning process of the students. She thought she did not have enough ideas and lacked the necessary critical skills required in her new conceived space to evaluate and analyze the issues discussed in the course. In addition, she found grammar to be a requirement of communications in her new conceived space. As she thought she had grammar problems, it inhibited her to speak and by not speaking she would do face saving. She was not invested in the practices of her new EAP and mainstream conceived social space such as giving feedback and speaking in the classroom, because they were not the same as the practices in her previous Japanese university.

The lived space also positioned her as a silent individual in her classroom interactions. This study followed Shelly in two semesters of study and in four courses. Shelly's silence had various meanings and it should be understood in relation to the power the other individuals and social space, as a social being, exerted upon her, and her reaction toward the social space forces. In her EAP course, she constructed other individuals as better English language learners. However, she could still participate and was allowed to partake in activities by other international peers in her classroom activities. In other words, she was given the opportunity to stay in the periphery of her classroom' CofP and choose to minimally verbally and nonverbally participate in the act of communication. During this period, she only linguistically constructed others as better language learners (Norton & Toohey, 2001). She also thought the reason she could not participate was a lack of confidence in her additional language otherwise if the conversation were in Japanese, she would participate and contribute to the flow of conversation. The power dynamics and difference (Watson-Gegeo, 2004, p. 334) in the European studies' course were so phenomenal that she could not bear. The students from the English-speaking backgrounds were not only linguistically dominant but also socio-historically and culturally invested in the course content, something Shelly could hardly put up with. The result of this was her inability to stand the pressure. Hence, she dropped the course to get back to a safe heaven. Her interactions in Spanish course, and her silence were again different. Although there were New Zealanders and Americans in the class, the medium of instruction was not English. She could not communicate with her classmates in English but still she could put up with the pressures in the social space of her classroom. In the writing course, she could use what she had learned in EAP and effectively

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witness a change in her participation though she was silent. All silence is to be understood in connection to all the three aspects social space.

The findings suggest, therefore, that Shelly's multiple identities should be seen from an ecological perspective (Steffensen & Kramsch, 2017, p. 9) wherein her identities emerged in the interplay between the dynamics of various forces in the social space. Shelly experienced the social space of the university and not one of the three aspects of space. In other words, she experienced the three aspects of social space at the same time without even being conscious of experiencing them. All the three aspects of the social space (perceived, conceived, and lived) (Lefebvre, 1991, p.33) impacted on Shelly and made her silent in her interactions. The findings of this study thus confirm the previous studies' findings (Blommaert, Collins, & Slembrouck, 2005, p. 198) that "a lack of competence to communicate adequately is not seen as a problem of the speaker, but as a problem for the speaker, lodged not in individual forms of deficit or inability but in the connection between individual communicative potential and requirements produced by the environment." Shelly's language socialization (Ochs & Schieffelin, 2008) to master the norms of her new social space was a process fraught with challenges which made her silent in her interactions in her EAP and mainstream courses in this study. However, despite the silence enacted during her engagement in the new academic and social environment, Shelly was not subject to the stereotype of international students as being deficit or passive. The silence displayed was by no means a form of submission or dis-engagement. Shelly instead exercised needs-response agency and agency as becoming when she identified "gaps" and areas for improvement.

The findings of this study showed that silence can be a characteristic of pro-active learners and can go alongside with and complement agency. Shelly's account shows that because of the conditions of her social space, she was pro-active in strategically using silence to create a safe space and gain a sense of security. Her way of resorting to silence could be seen as a stepping stone to agency as she protected herself through silence. This echoes existing scholarly work that points out that international students proactively choose "silence as ways to empower themselves and show resistance to dominant discourses" (Wu, 2019, p. 8) in a host environment in favor of the 'English-only rule' that unintentionally marginalizes this group who lacks the power of being a native speaker of English. In this regard, silence is intertwined with agency and represents a response to a certain condition or situation (Eteläpelto et al., 2013, p. 56). Therefore, silence should not be seen as a manifestation of deficiency on the part of

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international students. Rather it should be conceptualized as the space and venue for the potential formation or enactment of international students' agency. Importantly, the way Shelly was pro-active in resorting to silence shows that silence was not an inherent trait for her. This has a significant implication for the practice of teaching because it challenges the widespread assumption that silence is a negative aspect of learning. Instead, silence can represent learners' pro-active effort to create a safe space when they first interact with an unfamiliar learning environment and an important step in their transition to the transnational context. Silence can also provide learners with the conditions to listen to and internalize new concepts before they can verbally interact with other peers and teachers. Therefore, teachers may need to recognize this process and empathize with learners during this silence phase so that a supportive and conducive learning environment can be fostered.

CONCLUSION

Sample class interactions revealed that Shelly stayed relatively silent during her entire EAP and mainstream courses. The results from Shelly's experience confirm findings from the previous studies that showed silence is not an inherent trait (e.g.Morita, 2004), which is connected to language ability, student ethnicity, knowledge, shyness, or apathy as often regarded by the school staff and students (Cho, 2013; Duff & Anderson, 2015). There were multiple forces which contributed to Shelly's silence. These were: (1) unfamiliarity with the perceived space of New Zealand including the physical arrangement of classes and the wider perceived space; (2) unfamiliarity with the conceived space of NZU including expectations of courses in her new social space; values and norms admired and promoted in the new social space, and her disinterest in the course themes; (3) unequal power relations between her and the rest of her classmates, and her positioning herself as less knowledgeable, and positioning others as good language learners in the lived space.

As evident from the data presented in this paper, Shelly's new social space did not offer her the same set of social relations she experienced in Japan (Watson-Gegeo, 2004, p. 334). Shelly's nonverbal participation in the form of gestures, smiles, etc. shows that although students like Shelly may not verbally utter things, they are constantly active in making sense of interactions in the classroom and they constantly interpret the here and now of the interactions. Shelly's silence thus showed that silence is constructed in social space. Silence could

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be a form of strategy in the negotiation of social positioning in the space of university.

This study's contribution, thus, to the scholarly debate on silence is that silence is the outcome of an interplay among three forces of perceived, conceived, and lived space. To understand silence, then, it is imperative to consider the physical space, the way the space is supposed to be used by the occupants of that space, and the everyday interactions among the participants and their agency. Silence should be interpreted from linguistic, affective, cognitive, and sociocultural standpoints and any interpretation of silence without considering the social space and its constituting elements is not all-inclusive and hence incomplete.

This study brings under spotlight the production of silence by Asian international students in English language courses by critically analyzing it from the perceived, conceived, and lived aspects of space. Previous studies on silence have not investigated it from a spatial perspective and this study is the first to do so. Moreover, all other studies in international education and language socialization focused on only two aspects of space: conceived and lived. No study to date has focused on the significance of the perceived space in positioning international students into a silent position. This contribution is unique as only this study has redressed this gap in the literature. Furthermore, this study goes beyond the conceptualization of investment model and introduces the concept of "academic social space" as a theoretical construct to understand the silence of international students in the classroom.

AUTHOR CONTRIBUTION

The first author conducted the study, collected and analyzed the data, and wrote the first draft of the paper. The second author provided feedback on the first draft.

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APPENDIX A

Transcript key	
,	A comma shows continuing/rising intonation
-	A dash shows a cut- off utterance or a short pause
[]	Brackets show information to clarify the meaning of the utterance/words
“”	Quotation mark indicates reported speech
	A period marks the end of an utterance and a pause
?	A question mark shows a rising intonation
!	An exclamation mark shows the utterance has been mentioned with an excited tone

APPENDIX B

Types of data collected and analyzed	Timeframe	Phase	Amount/number
Self-reports by focal student (a) Diaries in Microsoft Word format (b) face-to-face conversation after her classes (c) email correspondence (d) text messaging	Weekly (November 2011 to July 2012)	1 & 2	a. #23 b. #20 c. #30 d. #15
Interviews with focal student	Fortnightly (first two weeks) and then weekly (November 2011 to July 2012)	1 & 2	EAP:3 hours 15 minutes Mainstream: 5 hours
Classroom observations and video/audio recordings,	Weekly (November 2011 to July 2012)	1 & 2	EAP: 9 hours and 14 minutes Mainstream: 9 hours and 49 minutes EAP: 14.5 hours Mainstream: 32.5 hours
Field notes	Weekly (November 2011 to July 2012)	1 & 2	EAP: 14.5 hours Mainstream: 32.5 hours
interviews with teacher/tutor	End of the course	1 & 2	EAP: 60 minutes Mainstream: 1 hour and 27 minutes

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Table B1 *(Continued)*

Types of data collected and analyzed	Timeframe	Phase	Amount/number
Other documents (a) course outlines, (b) course reading materials, (c) students' writings, (d) copies of PowerPoint slides the focal student presented at mid and final semester, (e) video recordings of the final oral presentations in the EAP course, (f) copies of the writing assignments she submitted, and (g) online institutional documents.	(November 2011 to July 2012)	1 & 2	a. #1 b. 1 booklet c. 5 samples d. #3 e. #1 f. #2 g. University website

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APPENDIX C

SAMPLE CLASS MATERIAL

Quotations Checklist

Read your partner's draft and answer the following questions.

1. Is there an in-text reference for every quotation?

   Yes / No (delete one)

   Suggestions for improvement:

2. Is every in-text reference correctly written (i.e. author + date + page number)?

   Yes / No (delete one)

   Suggestions for improvement:

3. Is the source for every in-text reference included in the end-of-text references?

   Yes / No (delete one)

   Suggestions for improvement:

4. Are the end-of-text references correctly written?

   Yes / No (delete one)

   Suggestions for improvement:

5. Is every long quotation clearly integrated into the essay (e.g. as an example, **or** with an explanation, **or** with a summary)?

   Yes / No (delete one)

   Suggestions for improvement:

6. What percentage of the essay do you estimate quotations account for?

   Suggestions for improvement:

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